

CAPTURING THE DESENSITIZED CONFORMATION OF THE MUSCLE-TYPE NICOTINIC ACETYLCHOLINE RECEPTOR

Korantin LE MOUËL¹, Camille HÉNAULT², Anna ANANCHENKO², Eleftherios
ZARKADAS³, Antoine EVEN¹, Alexandre POZZA¹, François DEHEZ⁴, Pierre-Jean
CORRINGER⁵, John BAENZIGER², Manuela ZOONENS^{1,*}

¹ Université Paris Cité, CNRS, Biochimie des Protéines Membranaires, F-75005 Paris, France; ² Department of Biochemistry, Microbiology and Immunology, University of Ottawa, Ottawa, Canada; ³ Univ. Grenoble Alpes, CNRS, CEA, IBS, F-38000 Grenoble, France; ⁴ CNRS, LPCT, Université de Lorraine, F-54000 Nancy, France; ⁵ Institut Pasteur, Université Paris Cité, CNRS UMR 3571, Channel-Receptors Unit, Paris, France
(corresponding author: manuela.zoonens@ibpc.fr)

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ABSTRACT

The nicotinic acetylcholine receptor (nAChR) from electric fish is a key model for understanding ligand-gated ion channel (pLGIC) function. Upon neurotransmitter binding, these receptors undergo successive conformational transitions from resting (closed-channel) to active (open-channel), and then desensitized (closed-channel) states. Recent structural data have clarified the coupling between agonist-induced changes in the extracellular domain (ECD) and motions of the pore-lining M2 α -helices in the transmembrane domain (TMD)^{1,2}. However, agonist-bound *Torpedo* nAChR structures revealed lipid densities in the central pore, likely artefacts from reconstitution in protein-based nanodiscs³. Moreover, molecular dynamics simulations show that these structures adopt a hydrated, ion-permeable pore, inconsistent with desensitization.

To address this, we used amphipathic polymers (CyclAPol C₈-C₀-50)^{4,5} to directly extract nAChR from fish electric organ membranes. This allows us to bypass reconstitution steps and preserve the native lipid context, which proves to be enriched in docosahexaenoic acid (DHA)-containing phospholipids. The cryo-EM structure of amphipol-purified, agonist-bound nAChR differs from those obtained in protein-based nanodiscs: while the agonist-bound ECD signatures are conserved, the TMD exhibits structural differences and a lack of lipid densities, leading to the closure of hydrophobic pore gates, consistent with the expected desensitized state. This enables us to rectify the

incorrect open-channel desensitized conformation reported in the literature and to fill a gap in the receptor's conformational landscape. Finally, this highlights the impact of the amphipathic environment on membrane protein structural studies and the need to compare different solubilization strategies to assess whether a given conformation is mimetic-specific or robust⁶.

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